Returning Home After an Evacuation

Return only when the authority responsible for your location says your specific area is open. A lifted evacuation order does not guarantee that every road, building, or utility is safe.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Do not enter a dangerous property. If you see or suspect structural collapse, fire, smoke, a gas leak, damaged electrical equipment, downed lines, or a chemical release, move away and follow emergency officials' instructions.

1. BEFORE RETURNING

- ☐ Wait for official authorization to return; verify that it applies to the correct zone, neighborhood, or street address.
- ☐ Check official route restrictions, closures, curfews, and current hazards. Use the route authorities direct you to use.
- ☐ Tell a contact where you are going, your route, who is with you, and when you will check in. Do not return alone if officials advise against it.
- ☐ Bring a charged phone and backup power, battery radio, flashlight, first-aid supplies, safe drinking water, sturdy closed-toe shoes or boots, work gloves, eye protection, and task-appropriate respiratory protection.
- ☐ Bring essential medicines and identification. Plan for children, older adults, people with access or medical needs, and animals to remain somewhere safe until conditions are suitable.

◎ LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL

LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE USE

Official reentry portal or information source: _____

Utility emergency contacts: _____

Approved debris/disposal site or cleanup program: _____

Confirm each entry with the responsible local authority or provider after this emergency; hours, boundaries, routes, and services can change.

Returning Home After an Evacuation — continued

2. APPROACHING THE PROPERTY

Slow down, stay alert, and obey barriers and responder directions. Do not drive or walk around a closure.

- ☐ Look up and around for leaning or unstable trees, hanging limbs, damaged poles, downed lines, and structures that may collapse.
- ☐ Watch for washed-out or undermined roads, damaged bridges, loose debris, broken glass, sharp metal, open holes, and unstable ground.
- ☐ Stay away from smoke, ash plumes, flames, smoldering material, and hotspots. Fire can remain hidden in roofs, walls, vegetation, or debris.
- ☐ Do not enter or drive through floodwater. It can conceal road damage, carry sewage or chemicals, and be electrically charged.
- ☐ Avoid spilled containers, unusual odors, oily sheen, dust, ash, and unknown hazardous material. Do not touch, move, or sample them.
- ☐ Give displaced wildlife, frightened pets, livestock, and insects space; do not reach into debris or concealed areas.
- ☐ Keep clear of firefighting, utility, law-enforcement, rescue, and debris-removal operations.

Returning Home After an Evacuation — continued

3. BEFORE ENTERING

1. **Stop at the perimeter.** Do not enter if an authority has posted a restriction, a structure has shifted or is visibly damaged, water surrounds it, or you suspect an electrical, gas, fire, smoke, or chemical hazard.
2. **Use qualified help.** Ask the appropriate building official, licensed professional, fire authority, utility, or hazardous-materials authority to assess the suspected hazard. Follow their instructions before entry.
3. **Recheck from outside.** Look for sagging roofs or ceilings, leaning walls, damaged foundations, broken utility connections, sparks, hissing, smoke, or unusual odors. Never use a flame to inspect.
4. **Leave immediately if conditions change.** Do not retrieve possessions at the cost of personal safety.

4. UTILITIES AND EQUIPMENT

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Do not switch on, reconnect, relight, test, or operate a damaged or wet utility, appliance, generator, solar or battery system, fuel tank, or other equipment. Wait for authorization or inspection by the responsible utility or an appropriately qualified professional.

- Treat every downed line as energized. Stay away and report it through the responsible authority.
- If you smell gas, hear hissing, see arcing, or suspect a leak, do not create a spark or operate switches. Leave the area and seek emergency or utility guidance from a safe location.
- Never run a generator, grill, camp stove, or other fuel-burning device inside a home, garage, basement, shed, or near doors, windows, or vents; carbon monoxide can kill without warning.
- Do not use tap water, sewer service, heating or cooling equipment, elevators, or damaged vehicles until the responsible authority or qualified professional says they are safe.

Returning Home After an Evacuation — continued

5. FOOD, WATER, MEDICINE, AND CLEANUP

- ☐ Follow current drinking-water, food, public-health, and medicine advisories. When in doubt, do not eat, drink, or use an item exposed to floodwater, heat, smoke, chemicals, or unsafe temperatures.
- ☐ Ask a pharmacist or health professional how to replace medicine that may be contaminated, damaged, or stored outside its labeled temperature range. Do not guess whether it is safe.
- ☐ Photograph damage only from a safe location. Record serial numbers and make an inventory before discarding items when it is safe and authorities or an insurer permit.
- ☐ Match protective equipment to the task and official guidance. At minimum, cleanup may require sturdy boots, heavy work gloves, eye protection, protective clothing, and suitable respiratory protection.
- ☐ Ventilate only when authorities say outdoor air is safe and doing so will not spread contamination. Keep children, people with health risks, and animals away from cleanup.
- ☐ Never mix cleaners or disinfectants. In particular, mixing bleach with ammonia or another cleaner can release dangerous gases.
- ☐ Do not cut, sand, sweep, burn, pressure-wash, or otherwise disturb unknown dust, ash, insulation, damaged building material, chemical containers, or suspected asbestos. Seek guidance for assessment and disposal.
- ☐ Use safe lifting practices, take breaks, wash exposed skin, and prevent carbon-monoxide exposure. Stop work if protective equipment fails or the hazard is beyond your training.

6. HEALTH AND STRESS

Leave again if fire, floodwater, weather, air quality, structural conditions, utilities, chemicals, animals, or responder activity make the area unsafe. Call emergency services for an immediate threat. Seek prompt medical or poison-control advice for injury, breathing trouble, chest pain, dizziness, confusion, burns, chemical exposure, or other concerning symptoms.

Disasters and loss can cause strong stress reactions. Pace the work, rest, eat and drink safely, stay connected with supportive people, and seek a health professional or crisis service if distress is severe, persistent, or makes it hard to function or stay safe.

Returning Home After an Evacuation — continued

7. RETURN CHECKLIST

Address / evacuation zone: _____

Authorization source and notice: _____

Authorization verified on: _____ **Return date / time:** _____

Approved route and restrictions: _____

Contact told my plan: _____ **Check-in time:** _____

- ☐ Protective and communication supplies packed
- ☐ Property checked from a safe distance
- ☐ Posted restrictions and responder operations checked
- ☐ Food, water, medicine, and air advisories checked
- ☐ Damage documented without entering a hazard

◎ **LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL**

LOCAL INSPECTION INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE USE

Building / structural inspection contact: _____

Electrical / gas / water utility contact: _____

Fire / hazardous-materials contact: _____

Confirm roles and contact methods with the issuing authority or provider for this incident.

Insurance / recovery contact: _____

Unresolved hazards — location, description, and who was notified:

_____

_____

Do not enter / leave again if: _____

SOURCES

Sources: Ready.gov, “Returning Home After a Disaster”; CDC, “How to Safely Clean Up After a Natural Disaster” and “Keep Food Safe After a Disaster or Emergency”; FDA, “Food and Water Safety During Power Outages and Floods”; EPA, “Dealing with Debris and Damaged Buildings.” Accessed 2026-09-25.